



PAPER NO. **26-18**

WANDSWORTH BOROUGH COUNCIL

GRANTS OVERVIEW AND SCRUTINY SUB-COMMITTEE – 27TH JANUARY 2026

Report by the Assistant Chief Executive on Round 31 of the Wandsworth Grant Fund

SUMMARY

The Wandsworth Grant Fund (WGF) was established in Paper No. 14-523 by the integration of a number of the Council’s small grant schemes. All applications are required to secure the endorsement of a Ward Councillor (or two if Borough-wide). Recommendations for grants awards are made by the Grants Overview and Scrutiny Sub-Committee.

The baseline amount of funding available to be allocated in 2025/26 is £319,500. In total, 39 eligible applications were received requesting a total of £315,556.52. This paper makes recommendations regarding applications received under Round 31 of the Wandsworth Grant Fund, based on officer assessments, for consideration by members of the Sub-Committee. These officer recommendations total £141,108 to 17 organisations.

GLOSSARY

- |      |   |                                         |
|------|---|-----------------------------------------|
| VPT  | - | Voluntary Sector Partnerships Team      |
| CPSA | - | Community and Partnerships Service Area |
| VCOs | - | Voluntary and Community Organisations   |
| WGF  | - | Wandsworth Grant Fund                   |

## RECOMMENDATIONS

1. The Grants Overview and Scrutiny Sub-Committee is recommended to consider the applications appended to this report for funding under Round 31 of the Wandsworth Grant Fund and to make recommendations accordingly.
2. The Grants Overview and Scrutiny Sub-Committee is to note the decisions to award Wandsworth Grant Fund grants as may be recommended by the Grants Overview and Scrutiny Sub-Committee, will be delegated to the Assistant Chief Executive.

## BACKGROUND

3. Paper No. 14-523 established the Wandsworth Grant Fund by the combining of all existing grant schemes (with the exception of Youth Opportunities Fund – YOF) from 1st April 2015, building on the processes in place for the Wandsworth Big Society Fund and funded from within existing budgets.
4. The Grants Overview and Scrutiny Sub-Committee has been set up “to consider applications for grant aid to voluntary and community organisations providing services to residents of the Borough, and to make recommendations on funding amounts and the terms and conditions of these grants.”

## ROUND 31 ALLOCATION

4. The baseline amount available for distribution via the Wandsworth Grant Fund in the 2025/26 financial year is £319,500. Within this, £10,000 is designated for a single award Arts and Culture Capacity Grant and a further £20,000 is designated for the Wandsworth Arts Fringe which is held annually in June. Dispersed across the three rounds of the financial year, each round has an indicative budget of £96,500 ( $3 \times £96,500 = £289,500 + £30,000$  designated).
5. In total, 39 eligible applications were received requesting a total of £315,556.52. This paper makes recommendations regarding applications received under Round 31 of the Wandsworth Grant Fund, based on officer assessments, for consideration by members of the Sub-Committee. These officer recommendations total £141,108 to 17 organisations.
6. Funding of £159,427 has been awarded already this financial year, which leaves £65,073 available for grant award.
7. As agreed in January 2024 an SO83(A) (VSBEC-8) a variation to the Deed regarding permanent arrangements for the service delivery of the Wandsworth Community Fund (managed by the London Community Foundation) was made. £20,439 is available to be added to the current round of the Wandsworth Grant Fund.
8. Funding available for award this round including the remaining available funds and the Wandsworth Community Fund contribution totals £85,512.

9. SO83A number VSBEC-13 has approved £700,000 uplift to the Wandsworth Grant Fund budget, up to £300,000 to match fund money raised via a new crowdfunding initiative that will be set up and £180,000 on the appointment of a new Grants Officer over three years to manage the additional volume in grants, the crowdfunding initiative and ensure sufficient capacity is in place to support the allocation and continued robust monitoring of the programmes funded.
10. Given the high demand for grants in this round there is a proposed shortfall of funds available of £55,596 despite using the remaining grant budget and additional budget from the Wandsworth Community Fund. It is proposed to use £55,596 of the approved uplift to support projects within this round.
11. Using the funding streams outlined above (remaining fund balance, Wandsworth Community Fund and drawdown on the Cost of Living Funding), the proposed grant awards can be covered from existing funds.

## PROGRESS OF PROJECTS

12. The progress of projects in each of the last three years of WGF rounds are reported as:

**TABLE 1**

| Round | Date of award | Awards | Completed | Extended | On-track |
|-------|---------------|--------|-----------|----------|----------|
| 22    | 02/2023       | 11     | 10        | -        | 1        |
| 23    | 06/2023       | 13     | 12        | -        | 1        |
| 24    | 10/2023       | 32     | 27        | -        | 5        |
| 25    | 02/2024       | 11     | 8         | 1        | 2        |
| 26    | 06/2024       | 4      | 4         | -        | -        |
| 27    | 09/2024       | 10     | 6         | -        | 4        |
| 28    | 01/2025       | 13     | -         | -        | 13       |
| 29    | 06/2025       | 8      | -         | -        | 8        |
| 30    | 09/2025       | 11     | -         | -        | 11       |

13. Officers continue to monitor the progress of active projects and follow up with awardees where a final report is outstanding. Projects that are showing as on-track include those that are active as well as those that are completed with the outcomes delivered, but we are awaiting a final report. Active projects from earlier rounds are usually due to a delay in the start of the project. Officers are regularly in touch with grantees who submit photos and informal reporting, but the projects are only deemed complete once the final monitoring report has been received.

## WANDSWORTH GRANT FUND

14. The aim of the WGF is to support not for profit activities which benefit residents and communities of the London Borough of Wandsworth. As set out in Paper No. 15-106, seven themes have been defined to guide the kinds of activity the WGF will support: -

- Arts and Culture;
  - Children and Young People;
  - Environment and Attractive Neighbourhoods;
  - Citizenship and Civic Engagement;
  - Health and Well Being; and
  - Achieving Aspiration and Potential.
15. As agreed in Paper No. 14-523, all applications were required to secure the endorsement of a ward councillor (or two ward councillors if spanning the borough as a whole).
16. Grant applications were invited according to three size bands:
- Small grant - £500 - £1,000, limited to applicants with income of less than £100,000, no match funding required.
  - Intermediate grant - £1,000 - £5,000 limited to applicants with income of less than £250,000, 10% match funding required.
  - Main grant - £5,000 - £10,000, no income limit, 25% match funding required.
17. Round 31 of the WGF had a deadline of 6th November 2025. The guidance notes and website offered contact details of officers who could give thematic support to applicants.
18. In response to the latest round, 51 applications were received before the deadline. Twelve applications were deemed ineligible. The 39 eligible applications considered in this report are seeking total grants of £315,556.52.

## **ASSESSMENT OF GRANT APPLICATIONS**

19. Council officers have undertaken eligibility checks and assessed grant applications against the following headings:
- Suitability of applicant.
  - Strategic fit with the WGF themes.
  - Impact – i.e., is it clear what the activity will achieve.
  - Deliverability of the proposed activity.
  - Value for money.
  - Sustainability of activity once the grant has been spent.
  - Safeguarding – applicants must provide evidence of policies and procedures being in place and no funds are released until compliance is satisfied.
20. Assessments for each application have been undertaken by two Council officers with the relevant knowledge and expertise relating to the thematic priorities. Officers from different teams have been involved where an application spans two or more different themes.
21. The VPT team in the CPSA have checked all assessments to ensure consistency as far as possible. The WGF Round 31 General Guidance is attached as **Appendix C** and Members are asked to note in particular the specific guidance for each theme in this document.

22. Officers were instructed to assess each project on its own terms and to make a recommendation as follows:
- Recommend.
  - Recommend, but propose a lower level of funding.
  - Not Recommended.
23. Following this assessment process, the total amount of funding recommended following officer assessment is £141,108 to 17 organisations.
24. A summary of recommendations for all applications is set out in **Appendix A**. Individual summary assessments for each application are attached as **Appendix B**. The summary assessment form contains:
- The amount requested, location of project and endorsing councillor(s).
  - A summary of the activity from the application form.
  - A summary assessment by the assessing officer(s).
  - A recommendation including any conditions.
  - Brief information about the applicant.
  - Brief information about past WGF awards and their performance.

## **MONITORING AND REPORTING**

25. To measure the success of the delivery of grant projects, the Council needs to have information from each of the projects it supports. As stated in the Grant Offer Letter, all organisations that receive a grant from the Wandsworth Grant Fund are asked to complete and return a Project Outcome Report at the end of their project. Organisations can be asked for an interim report when staged award payments, linked to a satisfactory interim report is a condition of the grant, or on request.
26. Project reports are required to be submitted within 60 days of the end of the project. Failure to provide a satisfactory report could make any new application made to the Fund ineligible. Organisations are asked to provide advance warning of any serious or material concerns regarding the project as soon as the organisation becomes aware of such concerns.
27. The monitoring reports are reviewed by officers against the stated project outcomes, including confirmation that the grant has been spent in accordance with the terms and conditions of grant offer. Any variance on project outcomes is followed up with the grantee to determine if further action is required. Where grant funds have not been used in accordance with the terms and conditions the Council is able to request repayment of the grant in full or in-part.

## **COMMENTS OF THE EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR OF FINANCE**

28. If approved, the grants awarded in this paper can be met from existing earmarked funding, including the recent uplift to the Wandsworth Grant Fund. It will be important to monitor that the grants are spent in accordance with the terms and conditions of the grant offer.

## CONCLUSION

29. The Grants Overview and Scrutiny Sub-Committee will make recommendations on each application for approval by subsequent delegated authority as a non-key decision to the Assistant Chief Executive.

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Jon Evans  
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19th January 2026

### **Background papers**

There are no background papers to this report.